

****Password, Photo, Geolocation: A Insidious Spiral****

Those "digital proofs of love" that show a total lack
Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Authority
for the protection of personal data
(Gazzetta del Sud, December 7, 2023)

Times change, the digital world increasingly takes over our lives, regardless of age and context. Romantic affairs among teenagers are no exception to this rule and, more and more frequently, they are born, grow, and inevitably sometimes end mediated by a smartphone, a chat, a social network, or an app. Up to this point, there is nothing truly strange, even if it may seem so to us adults who have lived through the same stage of life in a completely different way. However, it is one thing not to be surprised or worried about the new myriad forms of first loves or the fact that the time of apples has become that of smartphones, chats, and social media; it is another thing to underestimate certain drifts that have nothing to do with love.

This is the case with the new digital proofs of love that are increasingly being requested among teenagers. These new pseudo-proofs of love vary among themselves but share a constant: they do not prove love but, at most, its absence, and they are damned dangerous or, at least, can become so. The most popular one usually starts like this: "I miss you, come on, if you love me send me a photo of yourself while you undress." Naturally, often in a different language than this and not limited to asking the other person to undress in front of the smartphone. The request is generally followed by a promise: "I will keep what you send me just for us." But then, we know how love stories go, or those flings that we always – and even more often as teenagers – confuse for love stories: sometimes they end, and it is rare that they end for both at the same moment, that they part with the same state of mind, that they both continue to care for and respect each other. And then it happens that those videos, those photos, those suggestive laughs take unimaginable directions, end up in a chat populated by friends or self-proclaimed friends, or maybe on social media, or perhaps on porn sites, in exchange for other photos. It is pointless to linger on what the impact might be on the life of a girl or a boy if a sexually explicit photo or video of theirs becomes public because it is easy to imagine.

But there are even more "sneaky" proofs of love that are much harder to recognize as dangerous. "I'm jealous, who are you chatting with all day? Who are you exchanging those photos with? If you want me to trust you, give me the password to your social media; if you are faithful, you have nothing to hide." Most of the time, the request follows a fight, a skirmish between lovers, or an episode that has ignited one of their jealousy. And often, one ends up giving in to the request, also because the mistaken perception of not really having anything to hide is widespread even among adults. And so, who cares if he or she can read my messages: "I have nothing to hide." But that's not the case. Gabriel Garcia Marquez wrote early on: "we all have three dimensions of life: a public one, a private one, and a secret one." Opening our social media to someone close to us at a certain moment in our lives is simply a bad idea. And not only because it is natural that there will come a time when we would like to confide in a friend and we would like to reclaim a digital space for our intimacy, but also because the risk of misunderstandings is always lurking in every form of communication, and in the terse and cryptic communications, based on acronyms, initials, hashtags, and emojis that characterize social media even more. It is difficult to imagine the consequences of a misunderstanding from the other person. The most innocent of our messages can trigger episodes of jealousy that are not always easy to manage, hurt the other's pride, instill doubts of every kind, and, unfortunately, in some cases, unleash violence, the feeling furthest from love. No, definitely, sharing the password of your social media or messaging apps with your partner is not a proof of love. In fact, do yourself a favor: if you have already done it, tell your partner that the true proof of love is mutual trust and that you read somewhere that exchanging passwords is wrong and dangerous for both of you, then change the password and reclaim your freedom.

But technology and digital habits are moving fast, and sharing passwords is becoming an outdated non-proof of love. In fact, there are now apps that can, with just a few clicks, allow anyone to monitor our movements step by step, where we are, and, in some cases and with certain limits, even who we

are with and for how long. Sometimes, there is not even a need for a specific app, because there are messaging apps that allow sharing one's location in real-time. And so, it is unfortunately not uncommon for the proof of love requested to be precisely this: "let me install an app like this on your smartphone or share your real-time location with me, so I will always know where you are and we will be more at ease." Yes, it seems true, easy, and harmless, but then comes the moment when it would be better if he or she did not know where we are, even in this case, for the most diverse reasons, not necessarily malicious: because we do not want to tell them that we went to the hospital for a check-up, that we went to buy them a gift, that we left school early for some reason. And at that point, we would feel prisoners of our proof of love, also because if we tried to deactivate the app, we would inevitably give the impression that we have something to hide.

Once again, therefore, it is not a proof of love but a form of unsustainable limitation of our freedom, and if one does not feel free while loving, perhaps one does not love or is not loved. It is better not to yield even to the request for this pseudo-proof of love if it comes, while if it has already arrived and we have already yielded, it is worth doing as above: "I have read that it is wrong and dangerous, call me or send me a message whenever you want and I will tell you where I am, and if we want to see each other, I will share my location instantly and not in real-time on WhatsApp or elsewhere, but I will uninstall your app!". Love, fortunately, even in the digital dimension, is more beautiful than this and deserves to be lived rather than becoming the object of this or that proof.